



BHASKAR PAUL

study in the May 2005 issue of *New Scientist*. Lowering the amount of protein and fat in the diet helps increase lifespan by nearly 65 per cent, it says. Yet another new study, published in the *International Journal of Epidemiology*, found diet rich in fruits, vegetables, fish, beans and whole grains as the foundation of longevity. Dr D. Prabhakaran of the Department of Cardiology at AIIMS, agrees: "Green leafy vegetables and fruits lower the risk of cardiovascular diseases."

It's not just what you eat; it's how much you eat," says Dr K.S. Reddy, Director of the Public Health Foundation Of India. For, scientists now believe the sure-fire way to live long is calorie restriction—reducing a body's energy intake below its energy expenditure. "It extends lifespan and delays the onset of age-related diseases." Last year the first systematic study showed that those on restricted diets had lower insulin resistance (high resistance is a risk factor for type 2 diabetes) and lower levels of low-density lipoprotein cholesterol (high levels are a risk factor for heart disease). Reddy mentions the Japanese island of Okinawa, home to the world's largest population of centenarians. "They follow a dietary philosophy known as *hara hachi but*—literally, eight parts out of 10 full."

Diet is not the only key. People who are active on a reg-

ular basis and consume fewer calories live longer, says a new study from the University of Florida: "Those who exercise can add three years to their life, and their hearts reap benefits from something as simple as a brisk walk for 30 minutes a day." In a study, *The Old-Old and Oldest Old* for the ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment in 1999, P.K.B. Nayar of the Center of Gerontology, Kerala, found that those who did moderately strenuous work in youth lived long. "That's because your body does a better job of circulating blood and oxygen—improving muscle endurance and strengthening the vital organs," says Dr Anoop Misra, head of diabetes and metabolic disorders at Fortis Hospital, Delhi.

But isn't frailty as inevitable as white hair and wrinkles? Researchers are questioning this assumption. The November 2001 issue of *Archives of Internal Medicine* reported a fresh approach. Frailty—muscle weakness, fatigue, a slow or unsteady gait, weight loss and lack of memory—is no longer seen as just part and parcel of growing old. Instead, it is newly recognised as a real condition in its own right. And cardiovascular disease is central to it. "In many cases, undetected cardiovascular disease is a major reason why people become frail," says Dr Ashok Seth, Chairman and Chief Cardiologist, Max Devki Devi Heart and Vascular Institute, Delhi. "You may not have classic symptoms like

In 60 years, life expectancy has shot up by nearly

20 yrs

The number of centenarians in India stood at

1.5 m

in year 2000

LOVE AND LONGEVITY:
Family ties keep Satyavati Suri (middle) ticking over. A key to long life, holds new research.

It's not just what you eat. The key to long life is also how much you eat.

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